

L

LARVA (plural Larvae) A young stage of an animal when it is completely different in form from the adult. Caterpillars and tadpoles are examples.

LEKKING Mating system found in some species that involves males gathering at traditional locations (leks) and competing for the attention of females by performing ritualized displays, building mounds, or undertaking other “show-off” activities.

LIGNOTUBER A swollen, woody base of a stem or trunk that occurs in some plants.

LITHOPHYTE A plant adapted to grow on rock surfaces.

LIVE-BEARER An animal species where the females give birth to live young, rather than laying or releasing eggs.

M

MANDIBLE A jaw or jawbone. In mammals it usually refers to the lower jaw, while in birds both the upper and lower parts of the bill are referred to as mandibles. Mandibles are also the chewing mouthparts of insects and other arthropods.

MANTLE (1) In geology, the layer lying between the Earth’s crust and its core. The mantle is subject to high temperatures and pressures, and can slowly move. (2) In zoology, a protective skin layer in snails and relatives that secretes the shell.

MARSUPIALS The group of mammals that includes kangaroos, opossums, wombats, and relatives. Unlike most other mammals including humans, marsupials give birth to offspring in a relatively undeveloped state, and the young then typically continue their growth within an external pouch on the mother’s body.

MEDITERRANEAN WOODLAND AND SCRUB A type of habitat found in warm temperate regions with hot dry summers and cool wet winters. As well as the Mediterranean area itself, this habitat is found in California, parts of Australia, and elsewhere.

METABOLISM The sum total of the biochemical processes taking place in the body.

METAMORPHOSIS Phenomenon in which an animal’s body undergoes

a major change in structure between the young and the adult form as in butterflies, or transforms more gradually, as in frogs. Metamorphosis occurs in many types of animals including crabs, starfish, frogs, and butterflies.

MID-OCEAN RIDGE A submerged range of mountains running along the deep-ocean floor. It is caused when tectonic plates move away from one another and new crust is created by upwelling of molten rocks from the Earth’s mantle. See also *Mantle*.

MIGRATION Movements undertaken by an animal species on a regular seasonal or diurnal basis. Some migrations cover huge distances.

MIMICRY Phenomenon in which one species of animal has evolved to look very similar to another unrelated animal.

MIXED FORESTS Temperate forests in which a mixture of broadleaf and coniferous tree species grow.

MONOGAMY Situation where a male and female of a given species mate only with one other and not with other partners. The pairs thus formed may last for life or for a single season, depending on the species.

MONOTREMES The egg-laying mammals, comprising the platypus and the echidnas (spiny anteaters).

MONTANE Relating to or found in mountainous regions.

MONTANE GRASSLANDS Grassland habitats occurring high on mountains, in both tropical and temperate regions.

MORPH A physical variant of a species. Some species have several clearly defined morphs, which may differ in color or patterning, but can interbreed.

MOLTING Shedding or renewing the body covering, such as periodically replacing the feathers in birds, or shedding the exoskeleton to allow for growth in insects. A molt is any period when this happens.

MUTUALISM A close relationship between two different species in which both benefit.

N

NICHE The ecological “role” that a living thing plays. Ecological theory states that no two species can occupy the same niche, because one should outcompete the other.

NOCTURNAL Active by night.

NOTOCHORD A reinforcing rod that runs the length of the body, it is the defining feature of chordates. It is present in embryonic vertebrates, but later becomes incorporated into the backbone.

NYMPH An immature insect that looks similar to its parents except that it does not have functioning wings or reproductive organs. See also *Larva*.

O

OLD-GROWTH Term applied, especially in North America, to natural forests that have not been significantly altered by human activity. In Britain the equivalent term is ancient woodland.

OMNIVORE An animal whose natural diet includes a wide variety of animal and vegetable food.

OPERCULUM A cover or lid. In many snails, an operculum on the back of the foot is used to seal the shell when the animal has withdrawn inside. In bony fish and larval amphibians, there is an operculum on each side of the body to protect the gill chamber.

P

PARASITE Any organism that lives on or in the body of another organism and feeds off it for an extended period. The relationship is beneficial to the parasite, but not to its host.

PECTORAL FIN One of two sets of paired fins positioned on either side toward the front of a fish’s body, often just behind its head. Pectoral fins are usually highly mobile and are normally used for maneuvering and braking.

PECTORAL MUSCLES Large, paired muscles that pull the forelimbs toward the chest. In birds they are the main flight muscles.

PEDIPALPS A pair of jointed structures found near the front of the body in spiders and relatives. They have various functions including sensing the environment and as aids in reproduction, depending on the species. The large “pincers” of scorpions are pedipalps.

PENINSULA An area of land jutting out into the sea or a lake.

PERMAFROST Permanently frozen ground (technically, ground that has remained frozen for at least two

years). It is characteristic of polar regions. See also *Tundra*.

PHOTOSYNTHESIS The process by which green plants and algae utilize the sun’s energy, carbon dioxide, and water to produce energy-containing sugars. Oxygen is a byproduct.

PHYTOPLANKTON Plantlike lifeforms of the plankton that produce their own food by photosynthesis. They are mainly microscopic algae. See also *Algae*, *Plankton*, *Zooplankton*.

PLANKTON Mainly microscopic floating lifeforms living in open water that cannot swim strongly (or at all) and so drift with the currents.

PLATE TECTONICS A concept that explains how the plates that make up the Earth’s crust move. They are created at midocean ridges and destroyed where plates collide or slide by each other.

PNEUMATOPHORE (1) An aerial root produced by some trees living in waterlogged conditions to take in the air their roots need. (2) The large gas-filled float of the Portuguese man o’ war (a relative of jellyfish).

POLYGAMY The situation where members of a species (male, female, or both sexes) have multiple sexual partners.

PREDATOR An animal that hunts and eats other animals.

PREHENSILE Capable of grasping, such as the tails of some monkeys.

PREY Any animal hunted for food by another animal or trapped by a carnivorous plant.

PROBOSCIS In mammals, an elongated nose or snout, such as that of an elephant, or an elongated mouthpart for sipping liquids as seen in many butterflies.

PUFFBALLS Fungi that produce globular fruiting bodies, which release spores in a dustlike cloud when they rupture.

PUNA GRASSLAND An ecoregion of the montane grasslands in the Andes mountains of South America.

PUP A name for the young of many animals, including sharks and seals as well as (more obviously) dogs.

PUPA In many insects such as flies and moths, a stage in which the larval body is broken down and rebuilt as an adult. See also *Larva*.